

Saints and Sinners

By William E. McCraw – Sir William of Kintail

How did two best friends end up as bitter rivals? Why did their love for one another turn to ashes and destroy what they built together? And is there hope? Can a man fall from grace, and truly ever be redeemed?

History is the record of the human experience. Often, we ignore that uncomfortable thought. We find it difficult to accept that Genghis Khan once rushed to the arms of his mother, with tear filled eyes; just waiting for that magical kiss. The one kiss that every mother gives, that somehow erases the ‘*terror*’ and pain of a skinned knee. Instead, we read the footnotes of his life and forget that he was at one time, just like each of us.

It is never as rigid as it appears. The problem of human beings is the condition of being human. We are subject to life, the whole range of emotions, and our reactions to the world around us.

Henry FitzEmpress (Curtmantle) – The King

Henry Curtmantle, great-grandson of William the Conqueror, was born to Geoffrey V (Plantagenet), Count of Anjou (also known as Geoffrey the Fair) and the Empress Matilda (also known as Maud.). She was the legitimate/sole heir to the throne, and daughter of Henry I, King of England, Duke of Normandy.

Matilda's brother, William Ætheling (King Henry I's only legitimate son), tragically died in a shipwreck on 25 November 1120. The King of England's second marriage was childless. To secure his succession, Henry I gathered his council at Westminster. On 25 December 1126 the nobles present swore to recognize Matilda and any of her future legitimate heirs, as his successors and rightful heirs to the throne of England.

By age two, (on 01 December 1135) - Henry II had lost his grandfather and namesake. Matilda's cousin, Stephen of Blois, took the death of his uncle (the King), as an opportunity to seize power. Accompanied by his military household, and with the support of his brother, Henry of Blois, the bishop of Winchester – Stephen reached the edge of London. Stephen's Brother convincingly argued that the late King had been wrong to insist that his court take the oath, and suggested that the King had changed his mind on his deathbed. Supported by the English church and

the cities who wished to garner favor from Stephen, he was crowned King of England on 22 December 1135.

Empress Matilda, the late King's daughter and rightful heir to the throne, never ceded her claim to England or Normandy. Tensions mounted between Stephen and Matilda. This divided England and culminated in a civil war that would be known as 'The Anarchy'.

While growing up, Henry II spent much of his time in Normandy, England, and Anjou. While in Anjou a well-known scholar, Peter of Saintes began young Henry's education. Henry's father sent him to Bristol at the age of nine to live in his Uncle's house (Robert of Gloucester). During this point of his education Henry II studied the Canons of St. Augustine. Upon his return to Anjou in 1144, Henry studied under the famous academic William Conches who continued his formal education. By the completion of his education, Henry II had a mastery of the dominant languages of the day – French, and Latin, as well as a working knowledge of Provençal, Italian, and English.

Henry II became ambitious and dedicated to the vision of reclaiming his ancestral throne. At the age of 14, Henry II commissioned an army to serve under him. His mercenary attempt proved to be rather unsuccessful and revealed his inexperience as he lacked the funds to pay his men. Henry had first petitioned his mother for financial relief; but was denied. Though his reasons remain unclear, Stephen paid Henry II's Army and permitted him a safe return.

The exhaustive civil war (The Anarchy) spanned from 1139 until 1153 and occupied parts of England and France. Geoffrey, Henry II's father, abstained from the war in England in order to concentrate his efforts in conquering the north west of France and securing the Duchy of Normandy. From 1143 until the summer of 1144, Geoffrey systematically secured all of Normandy west and south of the Sienne; when he assume the title of Duke.

By the time Henry II was 18, Empress Matilda and Geoffrey the Fair ceded the duchy – appointing Henry II as Duke of Normandy. In September 1151, at age 38, Geoffrey the Fair died. The Empress Matilda commissioned a funerary plaque to adorn the tomb of her late husband. The plaque was composed of gilded copper with an enamel scene depicting her late husband, with a sword in one hand, holding a shield in the other. The ornate shield adorned with three rampart lions could at once be considered as one of the origins of the Royal Arms of England; as well as the earliest examples of European heraldry.

With the passing of his father, Henry II would inherit the titles and responsibilities of Geoffrey the Fair's lands. Henry II - now Duke of Normandy, Count of Anjou, Count of Maine, and Count of Touraine - focused on his mother and the lands he inherited. Empress Matilda moved to reside in an estate attached to the priory of Notre Dame du Pré, situated just south of Rouen. Henry II chose to build a palace nearest to his mother. Eleanor of Aquitaine, after fifteen years of marriage to King Louis VII of France was granted an annulment on grounds of consanguinity within the fourth degree. She was 30 years of age by the time Eleanor became engaged to her third cousin, Henry II. The young Duke of Normandy was 19. On Whitsun (Pentecost), 18 May 1152 the two married in West central France – in the city of Poitiers. The marriage would greatly increase Henry II's lands and support.

In 1153, Henry II returned to England, once again with the support of a small army and some of the major regional barons. Stephen began attacks on Matilda's supporters at Wallingford which were met by counterattacks from Henry II. A temporary truce was agreed upon, but it was met with resistance from, Eustace IV (Stephen's Son). Despite Stephen's unsuccessful attempts to save his son, Eustace IV suddenly died in August. At the same time, Eleanor of Aquitaine gave birth to Henry II's first son.

A second treaty would be signed at Winchester. This too would be temporary. Fighting continued between Stephen and Henry II. Both sides seemed reluctant to continue the fight, but neither Stephen nor Henry II desired to concede. Stephen suffered huge losses in Oxford and Stanford. For once, Henry of Blois the Bishop of Winchester and Theobald the Archbishop of Canterbury were unified in their desire to broker peace. Henry II and Stephen met again, this time to ratify a more permanent peace. Observing an ancient Christian tradition, Stephen and Henry II stood together in Winchester Cathedral, where Stephen announced the terms of the treaty recognizing Henry II as his successor. Stephen and Henry sealed the treaty with a kiss of peace (Holy Kiss, or Brotherly Kiss) and the war was ended.

Stephen died of appendicitis on 25 October 1154. He was buried next to his late wife and son Eustace IV at Faversham Abbey. Ascending the throne King Henry II was crowned at Westminster Abbey on 19 December 1154. He would become the first of fourteen Angevin Kings of England.

King Henry II was of stocky build and freckle face. He was witty and charming; but more comfortable when in the company of scholars than the common court. In

contrast, Henry II was also known to be ill-tempered, heartless; and if necessary, ruthless. At 21, Henry II had also inherited a world of complications.

The destruction from the civil war was enormous and costly. Henry II knew he would have to rejuvenate the kingdom. Changes had to be made. Henry also desired to change the relationship between church and monarchy; and sought to enhance his own royal authority over the church and its traditional roles in the kingdom.

Henry II's first priority would be to restore law and order; and reclaim the lands and power illegally held by the barons. Effectively, Henry II laid the groundwork/basis for the English Common Law as it is practiced today. Henry II was greatly assisted by the church and a young clerk in the household of Theobald of Bec, named Thomas Beckett.

Thomas Beckett – The Priest

Born in Cheapside, Thomas Beckett was the son of a wealthy merchant, Gilbert and Matilda. Despite his childhood fortunes, the Beckett household would experience a complete reversal of wealth. Thomas, at age twenty, would have to abandon his education and be forced to take on work at relatives' (Osbert Huitdeniers) business. Later, Thomas Beckett, would accept a position as a clerk in the household of Theobald of Bec the Archbishop of Canterbury. Impressed by Thomas' work and character, he quickly rose through the ranks. When Henry II sought advice to fulfill ministers' positions within the government, Theobald did not hesitate to offer up Thomas Beckett's name for the appointment of Chancellor.

Beckett's job was vital to the King, as it involved the distribution of royal charters, writs and letters. As Thomas' roles and responsibilities increased, so did his friendship with the King. People declared that "they had but one heart and one mind". The king and Becket soon became close friends. "Often the king and his minister behaved like two schoolboys at play."

The king would even ask Thomas to lead the English Armies into battle. Eleanor of Aquitaine was uneasy about Henry II's relationship with Becket; and it was often said that it "relegated her to the side-lines of affairs and undermined her influence with the King". When Henry II was away, "it was Becket, rather than Eleanor, who dispensed patronage on Henry's behalf and received important visitors to England". The two were inseparable; like two sides of the same coin.

Bearing in mind, the nature of their friendship, it should come to no surprise that upon the death of Theobald of Bec, Henry II did not hesitate to recommend

Beckett to the office of Archbishop. His election was confirmed on 23 May 1162 by a royal council of Bishops and noblemen.

Becket was ordained a priest on 2 June 1162 at Canterbury, and on 3 June 1162 was consecrated as Archbishop by Henry of Blois, the Bishop of Winchester and the other suffragan bishops of Canterbury.

After his coronation, Beckett sought more light in theological knowledge, canon law, the philosophies, culture, virtues and vision of the Gregorian Revolution. Feeling called to serve, he acquired a tutor well-disciplined in the faith. Beckett abandoned the materialism of his youth and fully embraced asceticism; and began adorning a simple monastic habit. Some of the ascetic practices adopted by Thomas Beckett was that he slept on a cold stone floor, wore a tight-fitting hairshirt infested with fleas that covered the majority of his body, and other acts of penance such as flagellation (a form of mortification of the flesh by whipping the skin) performed daily by his monks.

His dedication to the poor and destitute became renown among the community. Each morning, a group of the poor were brought up to the rectory where the newly dedicated Archbishop would serve them a meal, wash their feet, and give each person four silver pennies. Beckett found his heart and purpose the Gregorian vision of the church. It was obvious that he had found his sense of “home”.

The Best Laid Plans

Tensions grew between Henry II and his friend, when without consulting the King, Beckett returned the great seal used to authenticate royal documents; and resigned his appointment as Chancellor – only a few months after being consecrated as Archbishop. Being devoted to the Church, Thomas Beckett felt it prudent to absorb the role of Chancellor and further extend the rights of the Archbishopric. This would be the catalyst for a series of conflicts between the once, inseparable friends.

In Henry's eyes he thought this would place him in charge of the English church and he would be able to retain power over Becket. However, Becket seemed to change in his role and became a defender of the church and its tradition. He consistently opposed and quarreled with Henry, not allowing him to assert royal authority upon the church.

Henry II attempted to expand his empire into Wales and Ireland – much to the objection of Empress Matilda and the church. As Henry II's plans fell through, a

consolation came when Malcolm IV (King of Scots) was forced to restore back to England, the lands ceded to him by Malcolm IV's grandfather.

Meanwhile, Eleanor of Aquitaine, tried to assert her claim to the county of Toulouse in France. Henry II brokered peace in France with Louis VII (Eleanor's first husband). As a part of the peace, Henry II's five-year old son married Louis VII's two-year old daughter. The marriage was entirely political as a part of young Marguerite's dowry would grant the territory of Vexin to Henry II.

Upon Henry II's arrival back in England, around January 1163, Henry II was met with controversy. His officials were regaling him with reports of increased crimes of a very serious nature. Murderers numbering over 100 had claimed the right to be tried in the courts of the church. Exploiting a loophole in civil laws, anyone who had been trained by the church, yet had not received Holy Orders could demand this right. Contrary to the civil courts, the courts of the church were not permitted to impose violent punishments. This gave the offenders (who hid behind a liberally applied title of clerics and clergyman) a distinct advantage; as they could avoid mutilation or execution.

Henry II desired that the guilty face justice. Originally, Thomas had agreed to this. Beckett was a supporter of his king and best friend. Rarely were the two at odds. This was until Henry II had published the Constitutions of Clarendon.

The primary purpose for the Clarendon Constitutions was to see the clerks (clerics) and clergymen brought to justice. This was never what Thomas disagreed with. Thomas sought to preserve the authority of the church and the Honor of God. Henry II felt embittered and betrayed by Thomas – who was himself conflicted. Henry II summoned Thomas to stand trial. Before a great council at Northampton Castle on 8 October 1164, Thomas Becket was wrongfully convicted on the charges of contempt of royal authority and malfeasance in the Chancellor's office. Fearing the worst, Beckett flees the country to live under the protection of Henry II's rival in France.

Henry II issued edicts against Thomas and his supporters. Over the next six years Pope Alexander III would try to mediate peace between the two estranged friends. Several times, the two met in person, on neutral grounds, but failed to reach a peaceful solution. On 22 July 1170 Henry II agreed to restore Thomas Becket as Archbishop of Canterbury and return his possessions. Becket was ordered by Pope Alexander III to take the deal.

Pride Goeth Before the Fall

Prior to the meeting with Thomas Becket, Henry II elected his eldest surviving son to the station of junior (Joint) King. As a means to injure Becket's pride, Henry II revoked Canterbury's privilege to coronate the young King. On 24 May 1170, Roger de Pont L'Évêque, Archbishop of York, was at York with Gilbert Foliot, Bishop of London, and Josceline de Bohon, Bishop of Salisbury, to crown Henry the Young King.

November 1170 Becket excommunicated all his old ecclesiastical enemies, including those who had crowned the young king. In that day, excommunication removed the celebrant from all sacraments of every Christian church; banned contact with other Christians; and was often coupled with civil sanctions.

The Sentence

By 01 December 1170 Thomas Becket had returned to Canterbury. News of Becket's actions had reached Henry II's Christmas court at Bures in Normandy. Henry II's famous temper had reached its pinnacle. Amidst the loyal and ambitious members of the court, Henry II utters those fateful words "Will no one rid me of this turbulent priest" – or to some affect.

Variations of the words uttered include:

Guernes de Pont-Sainte-Maxence, claims he said: "A man who has eaten my bread, who came to my court poor and I have raised him high - now he draws up his heel to kick me in the teeth! He has shamed my kin, shamed my realm: the grief goes to my heart, and no one has avenged me!"

Edward Grim points out that Henry II added: "What miserable drones (the male of the honeybee that is stingless) and traitors have nourished and promoted in my realms, who let their lord to be treated with such shameful contempt by a low-born clerk." According to Gervase of Canterbury the king said: "How many cowardly, useless drones have I nourished that not even a single one is willing to avenge me of the wrongs I have suffered."

Regardless of the words he uttered, Henry II was surrounded by members of his court who were eager to prove their fealty and loyalty. Among those present were Reginald FitzUrse, William de Tracy, Hugh de Morville, and Richard le Bret who would become the emblems of misguided zeal and instrument of Henry II's ungoverned anger.

They set out to enforce what they perceived to be the will of their King. Dedicated to their self-determined mission they were going to force the Archbishop in Canterbury Cathedral to bend to Henry II's will, or failing therein, to exact their brand of justice upon this 'lowly priest'.

Becket had already received a letter warning him of danger when, on the afternoon of 29 December, the four knights crossed the channel to confront the Archbishop at his episcopal palace.

Murder Most Foul

Upon their arrival the knights placed their weapons under a tree just outside, and hid their armor under cloaks before approaching the Archbishop. During their confrontation with Becket, the knights made several demands - in particular, that he grant absolution to the bishops whom he had excommunicated. Thomas refused.

Walking away the knights issued threats and oaths. Moments later, Thomas heard shouting, doors banging open and a clashing of arms.

Becket began moving slowly through the cloisters to the cathedral. It was now twilight and vespers were being sung.

At the door to the north transept, he was met by some terrified monks. Thomas commanded the monks to return to the choir and continue the prayer service.

Frightened the monks hesitated at first but complied with the Archbishop's commands. Thomas entered the cathedral. Seeing that the knights were closing in on Becket, the monks slammed the door and bolted it. In all the chaos, these monks slammed the door leaving others behind. Trapped behind they began beating loudly on the door.

Becket, heartbroken by their fear shouted, "Away, you cowards! It is not right to make a fortress out of the house of prayer!" He reopened the door himself, then went towards the choir. All but one of the monks - Edward Grim - fled to the crypt and other hiding places.

The knights broke through the door, loudly demanding, "Where is Thomas Becket, traitor to the King and country?"

"Here I am," standing his ground Becket replied, "no traitor, but archbishop and priest of God!"

Once again, the knights shouted at the Archbishop to comply with their demands.

Becket answered resolutely, "I cannot do other than I have done." He turned to FitzUrse begging the question, "Reginald, you have received many favors from me. Why do you come into my church armed?"

FitzUrse made a threatening gesture with his axe.

Thomas valiantly stated, "I am ready to die," and without pause the Archbishop issued his warning: "but God's curse on you if you harm my people."

The wicked knights accosted the Archbishop in hopes of forcing him outside. Refusing to leave vespers, Becket wrapped his arms around a nearby pillar. Bowing his head in reverence, Thomas made peace with God.

FitzUrse flung down his axe and drew his sword.

Outraged, the Archbishop shouted, "You pander! You owe me fealty and submission!"

FitzUrse shouted back, "I owe no fealty contrary to the king!" and knocked off Becket's cap.

Thomas covered his face and cried out to God and the saints. De Tracy struck a blow. It first hit the arm of Edward Grim, who was nearby holding the Archbishop's crozier, then grazed Becket's skull.

Thomas wiped the blood, now running into his eyes and cried out in pain, praying to God: "Into Thy hands, O Lord, I commend my spirit!"

William de Tracy struck Becket again, beating him to his knees.

As Thomas fell forward on to his face, he found conviction in his path and uttered, "For the name of Jesus and in defense of the Church, I am willing to die."

Brutally, Le Bret struck the fatal blow, thrusting his sword deep into Becket's head, breaking the sword against the pavement.

Although Thomas now lay dying, Hugh de Morville struck the Archbishop once more.

The murderers, brandishing their swords, now dashed through the cloisters, shouting: "The king's men! The king's men!"

The Aftermath

The cathedral filled with people, initially ignorant of the atrocity, now looked on with horror. Ominously, a thunderstorm broke overhead. Becket's body lay in the middle of the transept. It remained where it had fallen for several hours; and for a time, no one dared to approach it. In part, they were frozen by fear, shock, and

confusion. In part, they were paralyzed by the shame of their inaction to prevent the death they had borne witness to.

Some of those still present, dipped parts of their clothes in his spilled blood, or collected it in small vessels to take away in anticipation of Becket's future sanctity. After spending the night on the high altar of the Cathedral, Thomas' body was buried by the monks the next day in the crypt.

Reports immediately circulated of miraculous healings connected to Becket. Facing increasing pressure from the people of Canterbury, the monks opened the crypt of the Cathedral so pilgrims could visit his tomb. An extraordinary wave of miracles was recorded and, in recognition of this, Becket was canonized a Saint by Pope Alexander III on 21 February 1173. His feast day, 29 December would commemorate his piety and martyrdom.

Becket's reputation as a miracle-working saint spread quickly and people from all over Europe started to flock to Canterbury in the hope that they would be healed. As well as visiting the tomb, pilgrims could also purchase a mixture of his blood and water, called St. Thomas' Water, which was bottled and sold by opportunistic monks in small lead vessels called ampulla.

Like wildfire, the word spread that Henry II had Becket murdered in a house of God and this was the starting point of his troubles. Henry II's wife Eleanor of Aquitaine and two of his sons, Henry the Young King and Richard, turned against him, engaging in a civil war, just on the heels of a civil revolt.

William I "the Lion" King of Scotland invaded northern England and for the first time it seemed England would be lost.

Redemption

Becket's assassins fled north to Hugh de Morville's Knaresborough Castle for about a year. De Morville also held property in Cumbria, and this too may have provided a hiding place, as the men prepared for a longer stay in the separate kingdom of Scotland. They were not arrested, and Henry II did not confiscate their lands, but he did not help them when they sought his advice in August 1171. Pope Alexander III excommunicated all four. Seeking forgiveness, the assassins travelled to Rome, where the Pope ordered them to serve as knights in the Holy Lands for a period of 14 years.

In the following year, 1172, at Avranches, Henry II was granted absolution for his part in the murder of Thomas Becket, but his penance was to provide for the

maintenance of 200 Knights Templar in the Holy Land and to undertake a crusade, either to the Holy Land or to Compostela. In his discussions with Pope Alexander III, Henry II agreed to allow the church courts to continue to deal with all criminal charges against clerics. In death, Thomas Becket had succeeded in preserving the church. The practice of the "benefit of clergy" went on until the Protestant Reformation.

However, as A. L. Morton pointed out: "Yet the victory of the church was not complete. The state had to surrender criminal cases: civil cases it retained. And during this period there grew up what came to be called the common law, a body of law holding good throughout the land and overriding all local laws and customs."

Fearing that his avaricious sons (especially the future kings Richard and John) would usurp his crown while abroad and knowing that funding 200 knights would bankrupt the kingdom, Henry instead offered strategically important tracts of lands in Waterford to the Knights Templar, including control of the lucrative ferry rights between Passage East and Ballyhack in County Wexford. In return, they were to provide sanctuary and protection to travelers, especially pilgrims. Henry admitted that, although he never desired the killing of Becket, his words may have prompted the murderers.

The Penitent Man

On 12 July 1174, Henry II headed to Canterbury, England. Just outside the city he stopped and removed his boots. He walked barefoot through the muddy road, dressed in sack cloth and covered in ash. He walked through broken shards of pottery, mud and whatever you can imagine on the streets of medieval England in 1174. As he walked, he left behind bloody footprints.

Henry II walked three miles to Canterbury Cathedral. When he arrived, he walked to the shrine of Becket in the crypt of the cathedral. Once there, he knelt in front of Becket's tomb and commanded the monks to whip him. They were some of the same monks who watched Becket be murdered just three years earlier. By being whipped, in front of Becket's tomb, by the monks who witnessed the murder, Henry II was spilling his own blood for penance. He received nearly 300 lashes.

The monks who participated, who witnessed the whipping were responsible for spreading the word about what Henry II had done. In his heart, he desired to seek forgiveness from God and all his subjects.

The event was described by Gervase of Canterbury: "He (Henry II) set out with a sad heart to the tomb of St. Thomas at Canterbury... he walked barefoot and clad in a woolen smock all the way to the martyr's tomb. There he lay and of his free will was whipped by all the bishops and abbots there present and each individual monk of the church of Canterbury."

Ralph de Diceto added: "He spent the rest of the day and also the whole of the following night in bitterness of soul, given over to prayer and sleeplessness, and continuing his fast for three days... There is no doubt that he had by now placated the martyr."

The next morning, Henry II found out that the Scottish king had been captured and the northern invasion was over. He took this as a sign that his penance was accepted by God. From then on, Henry adopted Becket as his protector. He made numerous gifts to the cathedral and visited it regularly on pilgrimage.

Despite Henry's penance and personal endorsement of Becket's burgeoning cult, he could never escape his association with the murder.

In the Middle Ages the Church encouraged people to make pilgrimages to special Holy places called shrines. It was believed that if you prayed at these shrines, you might be forgiven for your sins and have more chance of going to heaven. Others went to shrines hoping to be cured of an illness they were suffering from.

Becket's tomb at Canterbury Cathedral became the most popular shrine in England. When Becket was murdered local people managed to obtain pieces of cloth soaked in his blood. Rumors soon spread that, when touched by this cloth, people were cured of blindness, epilepsy and leprosy. It was not long before the monks at Canterbury Cathedral were selling small glass bottles of Becket's blood to visiting pilgrims. The monks also sold metal badges that had been stamped with the symbol of the shrine. The badges were then fixed to the pilgrim's hat so that people would know they had visited the shrine.

The Order

The conviction of the penitent knights (Reginald FitzUrse, William de Tracy, Hugh de Morville, and Richard le Bret), their acts of contrition, and their dedication of service to the church would also inspire the consecration of a new Order - the Hospitallers of St Thomas of Canterbury at Acre, usually called the Knights of St. Thomas, established in 1191 at Acre. It was militarized by Peter of Roche, Bishop of Winchester, during the Sixth Crusade 1227–1229. According to Pope Gregory IX this

was done thanks to the indulgence of the existing canons of the Hospital of St. Thomas in Acre.

The Knights of St. Thomas of Acre adopted the rule and customs of the Teutonic Knights. This was done with the counsel of the Patriarch of Jerusalem and Magnates in the East, who would no doubt have stressed the military needs of the crusader states. In the later Middle Ages, the brethren of St. Thomas based in London no longer followed the rule of the Teutonic Knights, but instead adopted that of the rule of St. Augustine. Some charitable work appears to have been maintained, and a grammar school was established at St. Thomas in London, possibly in the mid-fifteenth century. The final Master of the Knights of St. Thomas of Acre, Master Lawrence Copferler, surrendered the house and the Order was dissolved on 20 October 1538.

The destruction of English monasteries under Henry VIII transformed the power structures of English society. Henry had cut off all ties with the Catholic Church in Rome; and declared himself head of the Church of England. His intention in destroying the monastic system was both to reap its wealth and to suppress political opposition.

Between 1536 and 1540 he took over the 800 monasteries, abbeys, nunneries and friaries, some of which had accumulated great wealth and land (through bequests for instance). These had been home to more than 10,000 monks, nuns, friars and canons. Many former monasteries were sold off to landowners. Others were taken over and became churches, such as Durham Cathedral. Many were left to ruin, such as Tintern Abbey. A few monks who resisted were executed, but those who surrendered were paid or pensioned off.

The Order of St. Thomas was all but lost to the annals of history until 1974, when Masonic Researcher, Author and Brother John E. N. Walker succeeded in the re-establishment of the Order. After more than 20 years of research spent at Guildhall Library in London John E. N. Walker, has translated the ceremony of the installation of a Master for the Order of the Knights of St. Thomas of Acre. The ancient records of the Order, written in medieval French and Latin, had been deposited in the Guildhall Library and escaped the Great Fire of 1666.

After its re-establishment, the Order would emerge as the Commemorative Order of St. Thomas of Acon. In the spirit of the order established in Acre, this has and will remain forever an English Order. John E. N. Walker, who for many years

was the Secretary General of the Societas Rosicruciana in Anglia, would be installed Sir John of Dorking, our first Most Worthy Master.

The Lesson

So, what lessons can we draw from this?

Humans are complex beings. We are prone to submit to our baser nature. We can be rash, impetuous, and above all, imperfect; but we are not without hope. As we can see above, saints of knightly virtues can become sinners of murderous designs. Likewise, a boy from Cheapside can become consumed by money, wealth, power, and prestige – and in a single moment of clarity hear the call, and give his life over to Christ, and earnestly become the humble servant of the Lord, the bride of Christ (Holy Mother Church); and at once, her ever vigilant soldier. A king can be born into intrigue with ambitions far exceeding his reach, be prone to rage and furious outbursts, and can embrace humility to beg forgiveness from an enemy whom he had once held as a brother.

"The only difference between the saint and the sinner is that every saint has a past, and every sinner has a future." - Oscar Wilde

Each of us can choose how we will live. Each of us can embrace virtue rather than becoming consumed by vice. In our imperfect nature, we can fall from grace, and we can climb back up to embrace humility. It's never too late to forgive. It's never too late to ask for forgiveness and the opportunity to make amends.

"To err is human, to forgive divine" - Alexander Pope

To forgive is to 'fore' give; that is to say - to give yourself another chance, before it's too late.